Quality Management

Exam code: 9BS0

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Quality management methods

- Quality considers the characteristics and **features** of a product that **satisfy the needs of customers**
- Businesses need to **maintain a level of quality** that continues to attract and retain customers
- There are several approaches to **managing quality** in the production process

Methods of quality management

Method	Explanation

Quality control	• Inspecting the quality of output **at the end** of the production process
	• Benefits
	  ○ Quality **specialists** are employed to check standards
	  ○ An **inexpensive and simple** way to check that the output is fit for purpose
	• Drawbacks
	  ○ The rejection of finished goods is a significant **waste of resources**
	  ○ There is little focus on the **cause of defects**

Quality assurance	• Inspecting the quality of production **throughout** the production process
	• Benefits
	  ○ Quality issues are **identified early**, so **products may be reworked** rather than rejected
	  ○ The **cause of defects** is the focus, so **future quality issues** may be prevented
	• Drawbacks
	  ○ Staff **training** and a **skilled workforce** are required, so labour costs may be increased

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

Quality circles	• **Groups of workers** meet regularly to **solve quality problems** identified in the production process
	• Benefits
	  ○ Workers may be **motivated**, as they are **involved in decision-making**
	  ○ **Relevant and focused solutions** are likely, as workers are familiar with processes
	• Drawbacks
	  ○ Management needs to have **trust in workers'** views and solutions
	  ○ **Meetings** must be organised regularly

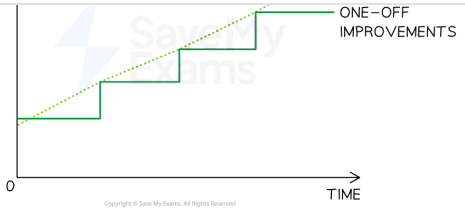
Total quality management	• Organisation of the business with **quality at its core** and with **every worker responsible for quality**
	• Benefits
	  ○ Quality in all aspects of the business improves **efficiency**
	  ○ A **culture of constant improvement** exists within the business
	• Drawbacks
	  ○ All **workers must be committed** and receive **significant, continuous training**
	  ○ Careful **monitoring** and **control** are required

Help me understand

Continuous improvement (kaizen)

- Kaizen involves a business taking **continuous steps to improve productivity** through the **elimination of all types of waste** in the production process
  - **Changes are small and ongoing** rather than significant one-offs, and they are **constantly reviewed** to ensure that the desired positive impact on productivity is achieved

Comparison of kaizen and one-off improvements



Continuous improvement is likely to lead to higher output per worker over time

- Elements of kaizen commonly include:
  - **Total quality management**
  - Just-in-time stock management
  - Teamwork and quality circles
  - **Zero defects** in manufacturing
  - High levels of automation
  - High levels of cooperation between **workers and management**
- Kaizen requires a **long-term management commitment to change**

Competitive advantage from quality management

- The quality of a business's products can provide a competitive advantage
  - **Unit costs are likely to be low** if a business takes a **preventative approach** through the use of quality assurance or total quality management
    - Low costs may allow a business to **reduce its selling price** to better compete with or undercut its rivals
  - Increased **finance may be available to fund marketing activity** to improve brand recognition and attract new customers
  - High levels of quality can be **used in promotional activity** and provide a **unique selling point** for businesses in competitive markets
  - Successfully developing a unique selling point for quality can **ease expansion into new markets** as a result of the positive reputation it creates

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